on merit. Familial ties, surname and closeness of kinship that usually influence succession based on genealogy, were peripheral considerations to the outgoing chairman. Ratan's selection was made by JRD after weighing the comparative strength of the contending candidates. It also added grist to the rumour mills that this appointment was confirmation that he was JRD's anointed successor.

The chairman, however, sought to dispel these assumptions. He asserted: 'If and when I retire, the appointment of the chairman of Tata Sons will be by the directors of Tata Sons. I am not creating, I am not appointing any chairman. Nobody can say in advance who the chairman shall be.' He thus kept many guessing while he carefully assessed if Ratan had the capabilities required to lead the group.